

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 11

Ancient Humans' Sleep

Ice Age History for Sleep

How Did Ancient Humans Sleep?

✦ ✦ ✦

A BEDTIME COMPANION

Two maps of the sites the episode visits, a deep-time timeline from the first beds to the house of bones, the places and finds you'll meet along the way, and a short list of books and places to visit, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

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ICE AGE EUROPE AND SIBERIA

The house of bones

Let's begin on the cold plains of eastern Europe, about 18,000 years ago.



Sites from the episode at their real locations on a modern base map. Ice Age coastlines and ice sheets are not shown. The star marks Mezhyrich, the model for our imagined camp.

AT A GLANCE

- One long Ice Age night, about 18,000 years ago
- An imagined family in a house of mammoth bones, near a river on the east European plain
- The camp is modelled on the real site of Mezhyrich, south of Kyiv
- Along the way: the first fires, the oldest beds and the nests of apes

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Places and finds in the episode

Nine places and finds, from the house of bones to the painted caves.

Mezhyrich · South of Kyiv: round houses of mammoth bones, found when a farmer digging a cellar struck a mammoth jaw.

The mammoth steppe · A vast cold grassland across much of Europe and Asia.

The east European plain · Bone houses in today's Ukraine, Russia, Belarus and Poland.

Kostenki · By the river Don, Russia: a great ring of mammoth bones, perhaps for storage or gatherings.

Sunghir · Russia: a burial whose clothes were covered with thousands of ivory beads.

Denisova Cave · Southern Siberia: the oldest eyed needles found so far.

Stone lamps · Dishes of fat with a wick; some of the finest come from France and Spain.

Lascaux and Chauvet · Painted caves in France, with animals painted by lamplight.

Altamira · A painted cave in Spain, full of Ice Age animals.

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DEEP TIME

A timeline of sleep

From the nests of our ape cousins to a house of mammoth bones, one slow step at a time.

AT A GLANCE

At least 200,000 years ago
The oldest beds

About 18,000 years ago
The house of bones

2017
The Hadza study

6–7 million years ago	The common ancestor of humans and chimpanzees lives in Africa, and probably builds a nest each night, as great apes still do.
Over 3 million years ago	Lucy and other australopithecines, with long arms and curved fingers, probably still climb into trees to sleep.
Nearly 2 million years ago	Homo erectus appears, built for life on the ground.
1 million years ago	Burned bone and plant ash lie deep inside Wonderwerk Cave, South Africa.
780,000 years ago	Burned flint, seeds and wood in hearth-like clusters by an ancient lake in Israel.
400,000 years ago	Fire seems to have become a regular part of life in many places.
300,000 years ago	Our own species, Homo sapiens, seems to appear in Africa.
200,000+ years ago	Grass beds laid on ash at Border Cave: the oldest beds known.

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DEEP TIME

A timeline of sleep

Then, much later, the scientists who listen to sleep.

77,000 years ago	Mats topped with insect-killing leaves at Sibudu.
50,000 years ago	One of the oldest eyed needles, at Denisova Cave.
34,000 years ago	The burial at Sunghir, with thousands of ivory beads.
30,000+ years ago	Some of the oldest paintings in Europe's painted caves.
25,000 years ago	The great ring of mammoth bones at Kostenki.
18,000 years ago	A bone house at Mezhyrich; our imagined night.
1960s	A farmer strikes a mammoth jaw bone at Mezhyrich.
Early 1990s	Wehr's long-night study: many sleep in two parts.
2005	Ekirch's book names "segmented sleep".
2015	Hadza, San and Tsimane: no clear two-part sleep.
2017	Hadza study: all asleep at once for only 18 minutes in 20 nights.
2025	New radiocarbon dates put a Mezhyrich house at about 18,000 years old.

All prehistoric dates are approximate; "200,000+" means at least 200,000 years ago.

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AFRICA

The first fires and the oldest beds

Now let's drift south, to the first fires and the oldest beds.



Sites from the episode on a modern base map; positions are approximate. The star marks Border Cave. Off this map: Gesher Benot Ya'aqov in Israel, far to the north, and the Tsimane of Bolivia. The San of the 2015 study live in Namibia, near the Kalahari point.

AT A GLANCE

- Grass beds on ash at Border Cave, at least 200,000 years ago
- Sibudu: mats topped with insect-killing leaves, about 77,000 years ago
- Among the Hadza, someone was nearly always awake
- Hadza, San and Tsimane slept about 5¾ to 7 hours, falling asleep about 3¼ hours after sunset

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Sites, finds and studies

For prehistory there are no names to meet, so here are the places, finds and studies instead.

Wonderwerk Cave · South Africa: burned bone and plant ash, deep inside the cave.

Gesher Benot Ya'aqov · Israel: hearth-like clusters by an ancient lake.

Border Cave · Lebombo Mountains, between South Africa and Eswatini: the oldest grass beds.

Sibudu · Above a river north of Durban: bedding mats up to about 3 square metres.

Lucy · A famous australopithecine skeleton, with arms still good for climbing.

Lake Eyasi · Northern Tanzania: 33 Hadza adults wore wrist devices for about 3 weeks.

The Kalahari · Among the Ju/'hoansi, more than four fifths of night talk was stories.

Namibia and Bolivia · The San and the Tsimane, in the 2015 sleep study.

The Ice Age sky · No star marked the pole; the sky turned near Deneb, in the Swan.

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WHILE YOU LISTEN

Things to spot, and what we imagine

A few things to listen for, and a note on what we know and what we imagine.

THINGS TO SPOT IN THE EPISODE

- A farmer's spade striking a mammoth jaw bone at Mezhyrich
- A fire of burning bone, with a low yellow flame
- The grandmother's little stone lamp
- Just 18 minutes in 20 nights when the whole Hadza camp slept at once
- "First sleep" and "second sleep"
- A sky turning near Deneb, in the Swan

WHAT WE KNOW, AND WHAT WE IMAGINE

The family, their dog and their words are invented; the world around them is built from real finds. The Hadza, San and Tsimane are modern people, not a window onto the past, and whether Ice Age people slept in one stretch or in two is still open.





Artistic impressions of grass bedding with insect-repelling leaves, and of bedding in a cave above a river, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

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FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Books to read

If you'd like to wander a little further, here are some trusted places to start.

At Day's Close: Night in Times Past, A. Roger Ekirch (2005): the book behind "first sleep" and "second sleep".

Catching Fire: How Cooking Made Us Human, Richard Wrangham: the idea that fire and cooking shaped us. Still debated.



An artistic impression made for the episode, not a historical record.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Museums, places and one last thought

Museums & places

Lascaux IV, France: an exact replica of the Lascaux cave.

Grotte Chauvet 2, Ardèche, France: a replica of the Chauvet cave.

Museo de Altamira, Spain: the national museum and research centre for the Altamira cave.

A BEDTIME QUESTION

If you were drifting off in the house of bones tonight, would you sleep nearest the fire, or nearest the grandmother's little lamp?

"Let the fire burn low now, softly, far away … The fire is still alight. All is well."

LISTEN TO THE FULL EPISODE ON YOUTUBE OR YOUTUBE MUSIC

Watch the episode: youtube.com/watch?v=yeMuBHqDXB8

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